— issue 018 —

The Morning Oracle

ONE COFFEE · PRICE · 018 · MORNING EDITION

✦ WHAT TOMORROW HOLDS, READ THIS MORNING ✦

MORNING EDITION
Saturday, October 17, 2026
FOUR COLUMNS · TWO PAGES

FIGURE OF THE DAY
200
blog posts for Voicy, a dictation app.

WORD OF THE DAY
Zero retention
n. — definition on page 2.

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☞ FRONT PAGE · AI

TOKEN PASS: $80 OF TOKENS FOR $30, BUT ONLY ON TWO MODELS

Vercel launches a monthly plan whose inference credit exceeds its price, for Pro teams.

EXCLUSIVE

On October 15, Vercel introduced Token Pass, an early-access plan: for $30 a month, a team gets $80 of shared credit on two models, GLM 5.3 and Kimi K3. More will follow.

The plan runs through AI Gateway and works with coding agents such as fx, Command Code or Pi, or a custom agent built on the AI SDK. You activate it, create an API key, then pick a model; both share the credit.

Zero data retention by default: inference runs in the US and EU, and prompts and responses are deleted after each request.

Two limits: unused credit does not roll over, and once it runs out, requests stop until the next period, with no extra billing. Predictable, but an overnight agent can stop mid-task.

TECH IN BRIEF

GITHUB STOPS PUSH EMAILS

Since October 15, GitHub no longer sends push-event emails, to prevent spam and abuse. To keep them, create a GitHub Actions workflow triggered on push that sends them through your own SMTP server.

THE LAB ANSWERS

The riddle

I'm paid monthly and don't keep: what you haven't spent by period's end, I erase. What am I?

Answer: a non-rolling monthly credit

THE QUOTE

"Programming is one of the most difficult branches of applied mathematics."

— *Edsger W. Dijkstra, EWD498, 1975*

TODAY'S PET PEEVE

THE DISPLAYED PRICE IS NOT THE PRICE YOU PAY

In the US, it took a federal rule to force ticket sellers to show the total up front.

You find a ticket at a fair price, click through the screens, and the total climbs at every step: service fees, processing fees, delivery fees. This is drip pricing. The US Federal Trade Commission addressed it with a rule on deceptive fees, in force since May 12, 2025: the total price of event tickets, mandatory fees included, must be shown before any other price.

On April 9, 2026, the FTC announced a $10 million settlement with StubHub. According to the agency, in mid-May 2025, after the rule took effect, the first two price screens often left out mandatory fees, and the third listed fees without a total. Buyers from May 12 to 14, 2025 are to be refunded; the agreement only has the force of law once a judge approves it.

Takeaway: a rule is not enough to change an interface.

BUSINESS LEAD

A browser extension that computes the real total of a cart from the first screen and compares it across sellers (tickets, rentals, bookings). Competition: the platforms themselves, now required to show the total for tickets in the US, and existing comparison sites. The angle: sectors the rule does not cover.

CASE STUDY

VOICY: A DICTATION APP BUILT FOR A FATHER, $16,000 TO $20,000 A MONTH

A Chrome extension built in two weeks for someone who typed too slowly, now a multi-platform product.

The founder, Kourosh, left Tehran for London at 18, taught himself to code during Covid and worked in fintech. A first app had reached about $5,000 a month without taking off. The idea for Voicy came from a hospital stay: his father typed slowly, and he wanted dictation everywhere. A Chrome extension, built on OpenAI's Whisper API, reached a prototype in two weeks; Windows, Mac, Linux, iOS and Android followed.

According to the interview published by Starter Story on October 14, 2026, the dashboard shows about $11,000 in recurring revenue, and the monthly total reaches $16,000 to $20,000 with lifetime plans (about $260, versus $8.49 a month). It has 2,500 daily active users and 1,400 active subscriptions.

Growth comes mostly from search: about 200 blog posts and 30 landing pages, in four or five languages. Lesson: serve people for whom the tool is a need. Caveat: figures are self-reported, not audited.

SCIENCE IN 5 LINES

A "PAC-MAN" ENZYME EATS BIOPLASTICS, AND ALSO BREAKS DOWN PENICILLIN

Researchers at the University of Konstanz identified a bacterial enzyme with two talents.

The team buried films of bioplastics (long-chain polyesters) ten centimeters deep in forest soil and measured the CO_2 released over a year: all degraded in roughly 250 to 330 days, versus 80 for cellulose; high-density polyethylene barely changed.

The enzyme responsible, an esterase anchored to the surface of bacteria, owes its nickname to its very wide active site. It also cuts the β-lactam ring of penicillin. Caveat: doing so in the lab does not prove it makes bacteria resistant, and common plastic was not degraded. Source: ScienceDaily, October 16, 2026, based on The ISME Journal.

TECH

VERCEL DAEMONS: PROCESSES THAT RUN WITHOUT A WEB SERVER

On October 15, Vercel opened Daemons in public beta: long-running processes that pull work from queues or databases, with no HTTP server. They run as containers in the same project as the app; Vercel keeps the configured number of instances per region and restarts the ones that crash.

Examples: Celery, BullMQ, RabbitMQ or Kafka consumers, Temporal workers, self-hosted CI runners. Setup: a *daemons* entry in *vercel.json* and a Dockerfile. The page says nothing about pricing.

BUSINESS ANGLE

Self-hosted CI runners are a cost and maintenance burden for small teams: an offer that installs and monitors them turnkey has an audience.

THE WORD

Zero retention, *n.* : A setting by which an AI provider stores neither your requests nor the model's responses once processing is done.

READER'S NOTEBOOK — SOMETHING THAT BUGGED YOU TODAY, AN IDEA:

The Morning Oracle — morning paper written and typeset by Claude for 1977 Éditions, from an idea by Michael Misran.
Sources: vercel.com · ftc.gov · starterstory.com · sciencedaily.com · github.blog · cs.utexas.edu